Tencent’s AI model Hunyuan Image 3.0 tops leaderboard, beating Google’s Nano Banana

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Tencent Holdings’ new artificial intelligence model, Hunyuan Image 3.0, has surpassed Google DeepMind’s “Nano Banana” as the leading image-generation model among both open-source and closed products, according to a major public leaderboard.

As of Saturday, the open-source Hunyuan Image 3.0 secured the top position in the text-to-image rankings on LMArena, an AI model evaluation platform originally started by researchers at the University of California, Berkeley.

The previous leader – Google DeepMind’s Gemini 2.5 Flash Image, also known as Nano Banana – rapidly gained popularity after its release in late August because of its image editing accuracy and 3D-figurine generation.

When Tencent released Hunyuan Image 3.0 late last month, the company said the model was “completely comparable to the industry’s flagship closed-source models”. It has 80 billion parameters, making it the largest open-source image-generation model to date.

An image of a Star Ferry-inspired spacecraft traversing a wormhole, generated by Google’s Nano Banana.

Parameters are the variables that encode a model’s intelligence and are adjusted during training. Generally, a higher number of parameters indicates a more powerful model, though it also requires greater computational resources to train and operate.

On Fal.ai, a global generative media hosting platform, Hunyuan Image 3.0 costs US$0.10 per megapixel generated. For comparison, Gemini 2.5 Flash Image and ByteDance’s flagship model, Seedream 4.0, are priced at US$0.039 per image and US$0.03 per image, respectively.

Tencent said its model was trained on an extensive data set comprising 5 billion image-text pairs, video frames, interleaved image-text data and 6 trillion tokens of text.

“Whether you’re an illustrator, designer or creator, this is built to slash your workflow from hours to minutes,” the company said in its announcement.

Hunyuan Image 3.0 is available on Tencent’s official website and has been open-sourced on developer platforms GitHub and Hugging Face, where it is trending alongside other recently launched Chinese models, such as DeepSeek’s V3.2-Exp and Z.ai’s GLM-4.6.

LMArena ranks models based on user preferences: users compare two images generated by different models and vote for their favourite. The platform has labelled Hunyuan Image 3.0's ranking as "preliminary", meaning that current votes are based on a pre-release version of the model.

The model currently supports only text-to-image generation, with plans to introduce additional functionalities, including image-to-image generation and image editing, according to Tencent.

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Vincent Chow is a technology reporter covering AI, with a focus on how society navigates the emergence of increasingly powerful AI systems. He previously covered Chinese society and was awarded a SOPA award for his culture reporting. He is currently supported by the Tarbell Center for AI Journalism.